Code Broken

by Olivia Cline



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JANE. (*sings*) Send him victorious! Happy and glorious! Long to reign over us; God save the king! All right, Bethy? You look like you've seen a ghost.

BETH. Jane? Get in here before someone sees you!

JANE. This your house? Lovely.

BETH. What are you doing here?

JANE. What? Can't I stop in for a hello? Just two old mates catching up.

BETH. Two old mates from where? Jane, you're not supposed to be here.

JANE. Afraid Pete'll come home and start interviewing me from whence and wheres we met?

BETH. No. Pete won't be home 'til half seven. But my kids will be in an hour.

JANE. Kids? That's brilliant. Didn't waste any time, did ya? Soon as the war was over you started "celebrating."

BETH. Don't be crude. We have a boy and a girl, 8 and 7. (*beat*) Jane, it's been years. What do you need?

JANE. To talk.

BETH. About what? What could you and I have to talk about anymore?

JANE. All of it. Us. The war. Bletchley Park.

BETH. No. We're not allowed to talk about it.

JANE. What? You and I both already know about it. It's not like we're *revealing* ultra-secret government information; we'd just be, like, *reminiscing* about ultra-secret government information.

BETH. Why?

JANE. I just need to! I just need to know it happened, that I'm not crazy. I can't talk to anyone else.

BETH. I know what you mean. You're not crazy.

JANE. You and me. We was there—important. We helped win the war.

BETH. The war is over, Jane. It ended a long time ago, remember?

JANE. Oh believe me, I remember.

While our traditional view of WWII is one of a war fought by men with tanks, U-boats, and bombs, there is another side to history. The women who contributed to military intelligence played a crucial role in winning battles, intercepting information, and breaking top secret Nazi codes. And no mission was more secret or more important in 1940's Britain than Bletchley Park. Hundreds of women worked tirelessly as code breakers to decipher Nazi messages and save lives. However, at war's end, these heroic women were sworn to secrecy, only allowed to reveal their involvement 30 years after the fact. Playwright Olivia Cline attempts to decipher the contributions and costs of their silent legacy asking the question: if history erases someone, can we still appreciate their contribution? Code Broken by Olivia Cline, based on the BBC interviews of Fiona Bruce.

TRANSITION TO 1954

JANE. Cup of tea?

BETH. Of course. So, what happened? I tried to imagine you were just off seeing the world and got lost in your adventure. Then you stopped sending the postcards. They just…stopped.

JANE. What was the point? You weren't coming.

BETH. The last one was from Africa. Where else did you go?

JANE. All the places we talked about.

BETH. Was it how we thought? The big adventure?

JANE. A lot of chasing.

BETH. Chasing?

JANE. Yeah, chasing. Chasing work, chasing money, chasing men.

BETH. Sounds glamourous, all that freedom.

JANE. Does it? You didn't used to fancy such... abandon.

BETH. (*pours the tea*)

JANE. What's this then? *Sunday Times* Codebreaker puzzles. Old habits, die hard, eh?

TRANSITION TO 1942

BETH. (*trying to get someone's attention*) Excuse me? Pardon me. I'm looking for... Hello?

JANE. You look lost. Where are you headed?

BETH. I'm...I don't think I am permitted to say.

JANE. Right. Is that your assignment letter? (steals the letter)

BETH. Hey! Give that back!

JANE. "Ms. Elizabeth Caldwell." From Chelsea. How posh! Commissioned civilian brigade. How did they commission ya, then?

BETH. I... I won a contest, in *The Times*. A puzzle.

JANE. So you're a brain, are ya?

BETH. No. I mean, maybe. They just told me to come here.

JANE. And you always do what you're told. I see. Well, you're in luck, Bethy. You're in Section G. With me, please.

BETH. Elizabeth. And what is section G?

JANE. Told you nothing, did they?

BETH. Not a thing. I got a that letter in the mail along with a rail pass. I haven't the faintest idea what a girl like me could possibly do for the British Royal Naval Service.

JANE. Codebreaking.

BETH. I beg your pardon?

JANE. We break German codes. Well, we try to.

BETH. German codes? Does that mean we can help...people?

JANE. You got a sweetheart, eh? On the front?

BETH. Pete. We were going to get married. Are. We are going to get married.

JANE. Uh-huh.

BETH. Then we'll live with his mother in Chelsea and start our family straight away.

JANE. Of course you are.

BETH. You're making fun?

JANE. 'Course I am. Well, just you wait. By the end of this, Pete's gonna bash *de Fuhrer's* face 'til he gone look like a shriveled raisin bulldog mess.

BETH. ...I think he already does look it.

JANE. Bethy…we'll get along fine.

TRANSITION TO 1942

JANE. (*comes in smoking a cigarette*) Ugh. Why you listening to that rubbish?

BETH. I'm working.

JANE. Working, my bum!

BETH. I hate listening to it, but I feel like I need to.

JANE. Need to?

BETH. It's ridiculous. It's not as if I'm going to hear about Pete on this thing, but still…

JANE. Hey, we only get a fifteen-minute break, no sense spending it in tears. Come on, Bethy. Your nose is going to stay shriveled like that if you don't learn how to have a little fun!

BETH. Yes, Sergeant Major! We were uhh…just taking our fifteen, sir. Smoking? No, sir. No smoking allowed in the house, we know that. Would you like to smell my breath? Yes, we will have those done for you by end of day, sir. Very good, sir.

JANE. (*trying not to let smoke out of her mouth*) God save the king. (*they watch him leave and dissolve into laughter*)

BETH. I thought we'd had it for sure! If your smoking gets us sacked…

JANE. Us? Never! They need us too much.

BETH. They need codebreakers. They don't need us.

JANE. (*sarcastically*) Right. Beth you're the most brilliant girl here. With your brain, we could have the whole world.

BETH. How did you get here?

JANE. Back stairs. They never check this time of day.

BETH. No, I mean here—Bletchley.

JANE. Oh, well, I volunteered.

BETH. You did? Wow. You must be very brave. Didn't you worry they would send you to the front? As a nurse or secretary?

JANE. No. I signed up for an adventure.

BETH. But as a woman—

JANE. The way I see it, war's the best time for women. Men stop looking at your chests and start letting ya get your hands dirty. This war ain't just about beatin the Germans, Bethy. This war is about beatin' the old way of life. Wherever that takes me is alright. What about you? I mean, you've obviously thought a little about what would happen if…you needed to…start over.

BETH. You mean if Pete doesn't come home.

JANE. Sure. Or maybe you decide that you're meant for a bigger life than housework. What then?

BETH. I've never thought of any other kind of life. Until now. Is that awful to say?

JANE. No, not awful. But you know we can do it, Bethy. Together we can change the world.

BETH. Just like my Pete… Well, come on then. Give us a smoke.

TRANSITION T0 1954

BETH. Please, don't light that. Pete can't stand the smell of smoke. Too many bad memories, he says.

JANE. Well. Wouldn't want to put Pete out of temper. Tell me, did you…ever tell him?

BETH. About Bletchley? No. And he doesn't ask.

JANE. Of course he doesn't. But I'm sure you know what he did in the war.

BETH. He was artillery.

JANE. Lucky him.

BETH. Pete suffers a great deal from his time in the war.

JANE. We all do.

BETH. I think it's different.

JANE. It is different. They did the fighting. We were the heroes.

BETH. That's…a subversive opinion.

JANE. Why? Didn't women make the bullets that he fought with, send the supplies that saved his life again and again? Didn't we provide the key to his success?

BETH. Very well, you're right. We all did our part.

JANE. And you're right. It's not the same. Pete can talk about it any bloody time he wants. But if I even try to whisper the word Fallschirm—

BETH. Don't.

JANE. —that happens. You would think it was our greatest shame. Our greatest shame that we were brilliant, too.

TRANSITION TO 1944

JANE. 2311 542 227

BETH. I…R…M. That's…that's impossible.

JANE. What? (*takes the paper, tries to read it*) Oh for God's sake, I'm rubbish at German!

BETH. It says that the division transfers to Fallschirm on the 3rd.

JANE. Fallschirm. There's not a city in Germany named Fallschirm.

BETH. It's not a city. It's a *luftwaffe* panzer division. Jane, if the cypher's correct, then we know where the German army is going to be in thirteen days' time.

JANE. Bloody hell. You're a genius.

BETH. We need to tell the Sergeant Major. The Colonels!

JANE. After this we should be the Colonels!

BETH. My god. Not bad for two ordinary girls.

JANE. Ordinary girls? I couldn't be ordinary if I tried.

BETH. No, you certainly couldn't.

JANE. This could be our ticket, Bethy.

BETH. To what?

JANE. Who knows? They see this and they start thinking them two girls got it figured out. Send them to Whitehall in London, the West Indies, Australia, Somaliland! And we'll go won't we? We'll see

the whole world!

BETH. But don't you want to go home?

JANE. Of course not! That's the whole point, isn't it?

BETH. The point was to win the war—to get our boys back safe. Then we go home.

JANE. Right. But surely they won't just let us go home, after we've made such an important contribution. Wait 'til I tell mum.

BETH. No. Jane. The Secrets Act, we signed it.

JANE. So?

BETH. It means we won't talk about it, not for 30 years.

JANE. Alright, so I won't tell mum. But she'll figure it out when she gets the postcard from Africa. Maybe I'll even sign it Eunice Dankworth, Royal Naval Services. She'd die.

BETH. No, Jane. I'm not going to Africa.

JANE. What about our plans to see the world?

BETH. Those were never my plans.

JANE. So that's it then? You'll go home and marry Pete. Whatever's left of him.

BETH. Don't say that.

JANE. You'll become some dull, empty-headed housewife and never do nothing else?

BETH. I'll get what I wanted.

JANE. How can that be what you want now that you've seen what you can do? You'd rather be used as a baby factory or—

BETH. —as someone's ticket to adventure-land? You only care about yourself and your plans. You've only wanted me along because you're not smart enough to do this on your own.

JANE. I've been a good friend to you since day one, Bethy. You know what, fine. Stay here. I hope you enjoy your worthless life. I'm going to get what I wanted.

BETH. I hope you enjoy your adventures alone.

TRANSITION TO 1954

BETH. I never forgave you for leaving.

JANE. I never forgave you for staying.

BETH. But you had your adventure—you traveled to all those amazing places.

JANE. I was chasing after an adventure we'd already had, that we could never top, and could never speak of.

BETH. What was so wrong with wanting a normal life? This. Here. My family. They are my adventure. But that was never good enough for you.

JANE. What was so wrong with wanting more? With wanting some respect and recognition for winning the damn war!

BETH. You want credit? You want a title? Well congratulations, god save Queen Jane!

JANE. They used us, Beth. And then they shut us up.

BETH. No. We did our part. We were sworn to secrecy!

JANE. We were sworn to invisibility! Then they stole our purpose.

BETH. I still have purpose.

JANE. What? Wiping arses and making roasts? You're happy with that?

BETH. Of course I'm not happy! I'm miserable! But what am I supposed to say? That I miss the war? That I hate my life? That I've already tried to end it twice? But you already know what they feels like, don't you?

JANE. Bethy…

BETH. Don't! I've no use for your pity. But you left me…you were gone. And now I'm just some crazy person whose house is filled with ghost stories. This is the way things are. And it's not perfect. And it's not wonderful. But at least we aren't all speaking German.

JANE. …I'm rubbish at German.

BETH. I know.

JANE. I am so sorry. I had no idea.

BETH. I know you think they took away our meaning. Ordinary is—

JANE. —not enough.

BETH. It's what we fought for though, isn't it?

JANE. How do you mean?

(door opens)

BETH. Ah, there you are. Hello darlings… Wash up before tea. And, Janey, you've forgotten your puzzle (*hands her the* Sunday Times).

JANE. She's doing the puzzles now?

BETH. (*nods*) I save them all for her. She's brilliant.

JANE. 'Course she is.

BETH. Her teachers think she has quite a bright future. We did that. She…is what we fought for…

JANE. Not bad for two ordinary girls.

BETH. Not bad at all.